Journal of Humanities and Social Sciences Invention
Vol. 0, No. 0, 2023, 1-7
ISSN: 2581-8791

A Study of the Response of the Non-Alignment Movement to the COVID-19 Crisis

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Publication Info

Article History:
Received: 00-00-2022
Accepted: 00-00-2022
DOI: 10.35210/jhssi.1.1.1

Keywords:
keywords

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Abstract

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INTRODUCTION

The COVID-19 pandemic turned out to be *annus horribilis*, in particular, for the developing world. The pandemic not only became a major public health emergency but its effects permeated to virtually all facets of the society, resulted in severe economic hardships for the developing countries. Not only did the growing demand for urgent healthcare and rising death tolls strained the national healthcare systems, the pandemic also disrupted global supply chains and international trade thereby causing pronounced volatility in financial markets, creating consumer-demand shocks, and generating a wide array of adverse impacts in critical sectors such as transportation and tourism (Morgan 2020, Mishra 2020).

According to the 2022 World Development Report published by the World Bank, economic activity contracted in 2020 in about 90 percent of countries. In 2020, the first year of the COVID-19 pandemic, the global economy shrank by approximately 3 percent, and global poverty increased for the first time in a generation. The report stated that the economic effects of the pandemic will be more persistent and severer for emerging economies. 40 percent of advanced economies recovered and exceeded their 2019 output level in 2021. The comparable share of countries achieving per capita income in 2021 that surpassed their 2019 output is far lower for middle-income countries, at 27 percent, and lower still for low-income countries, at 21 percent, pointing to a slower recovery in poorer countries (World Bank 2022b: 1-2). In January 2022, the World Bank stated that in emerging and developing economies, however, growth is expected to drop from 6.3 percent in 2021 to 4.6 percent in 2022 and 4.4 percent in 2023. Output in emerging and developing economies will remain 4 percent below its pre-pandemic levels (World Bank 2022a). the least developed countries, the landlocked developing countries and the small island developing states are thus the hardest hit. The United Nations Development Program projected in 2020 the income losses were expected to exceed $220 billion in developing countries. With an estimated 55 per cent of the global population having no access to social protection, these losses would further reverberate across societies, impacting education, human rights and, in the most severe cases, basic food security and nutrition (UNDP 2020).

The developing world has also faced high mortality rates. According to a 2021 study commissioned by Brookings, the lower middle-income countries witnessed a spike in mortality rates. Excess mortality rates (difference between observed and expected deaths due to COVID) was 35 times higher for Low Middle-Income Countries. Non-reported COVID-19 deaths and other excess deaths were also much larger than reported COVID-19 deaths especially in poorer countries Hence the study concludes that the COVID-19 crisis has been a developing country pandemic (Gill and Schellekens: 2021).

The Response of the Non-Aligned Movement to the COVID-19 crisis

The Non-Aligned Movement (NAM), a 120 Member States body, is the second largest grouping of states after the United Nations and also the largest collective voice of the developing world. Ever since its inception in 1961, the Movement has shaped its ideology according to the international scenario in a manner that best suits the interests of the developing world. Multilateralism has been a core tenet of NAM. Multilateralism literally means “many-sided” and is formed of the Latin words “many, and “latus”, side. In simple terms, multilateralism means the coordinated diplomatic interaction of three or more states (or other actors). According to Scott (2015), beyond that basic

quantitative aspect, multilateralism is generally considered to comprise certain qualitative elements or principles that shape the character of the arrangement or institution. NAM has reaffirmed that "the United Nations, its Charter, and the international law remain indispensable tools and central in the preservation and maintenance of international peace and security and the strengthening of international cooperation. While acknowledging its limitations, the UN, which represents a well-founded international legitimacy and through its multilateralism, remains the central multilateral forum for addressing the pressing global issues and challenges" (Non-Aligned Movement 2019).

Non-Aligned Movement has stayed relevant after the end of the Cold War and bipolarity in the global order and has constantly articulated the interests of the developing world with respect to major issues impacting them. As regards the health sector, NAM Member States are committed to achieve Universal Health Coverage by 2030. At the 18th Summit of Heads of State and Government of the Non-Aligned Movement, held on 25-26 October 2019 in Baku, Azerbaijan, the Heads of State and Government of NAM Member States welcomed the adoption of General Assembly resolution 73/131 entitled "Universal Health Coverage: Moving Together to Build a Healthier World" (Ibid) and in accordance with the Resolution recognised that health is a precondition for and an outcome and indicator of all three dimensions — economic, social and environmental — of sustainable development and that, despite progress made, challenges in global health, including major inequities and vulnerabilities within and among countries, regions and populations, still remain and demand persistent attention (United Nations 2018). The Non-Aligned Movement also accords a high priority to the Political Declaration of the High-level Meeting on Universal Health Coverage adopted on September 23, 2019. The Declaration recognises that universal health coverage implies that all people have access, without discrimination, to nationally determined sets of the needed promotive, preventive, curative, rehabilitative and palliative essential health services, and essential, safe, affordable, effective and quality medicines and vaccines. The Declaration calls to speed up efforts to build and strengthen quality and people-centred health systems and enhance their performance by improving patient safety, built on a foundation of strong primary health care and coherent national policies and strategies for quality and safe health services, noting that universal health coverage can only be achieved if the services and medical products are safe and effective and are delivered in a timely, equitable, efficient, and integrated manner. The Declaration further calls to promote increased access to affordable, safe, effective and quality medicines and to promote access to medicines for all (United Nations 2019).

Non-Aligned Movement, being the largest collective voice of the developing world, has voiced its concerns regarding the adverse impact of COVID-19 crisis. NAM's response to the COVID-19 crisis has been in line with the above two mentioned important health initiatives by the UN. A number of successful global initiatives aimed against the COVID-19 pandemic have been put forth on behalf of the Non-Aligned Movement by its chair Azerbaijan. Prominent among such initiatives are organising a summit-level meeting of the NAM Contact Group in response to the COVID-19 crisis, establishing a consolidated database on the basic humanitarian and medical needs of NAM Member States in their fight against the pandemic, convening the Special Session of the UN General Assembly on COVID-19, and adopting UN Human Rights Council resolutions on the equitable, affordable, timely and universal access to the COVID-19 vaccine. For the Non-Aligned Movement, equitable and non-discriminatory distribution of vaccines against COVID-19 is a factor that guarantees the fundamental human rights of millions of people around the world, particularly the right to health.

NAM has called on its Member States to cooperate in strengthening their health systems and to provide protection to the vulnerable population. The Communiques of the Coordinating Bureau of the Non-Aligned Movement on "the COVID-19 Pandemic" of 25 March 2020 expressed its concern over the rapid spread of the COVID-19. The Communique stressed upon the significance of multilateralism in addressing the pandemic and recognised that the preservation and strengthening of the values of multilateralism and all forms of international cooperation, which underpin the Charter of the United Nations and the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development were key at this crucial moment (Non-Aligned Movement 2020b).

On the initiative of Azerbaijan President, Ilham Aliyev, who is also the chair of NAM, an online summit was organised by the Non-Aligned Movement Contact Group in response to COVID-19 on May 4, 2020. The summit was called "United Against COVID-19" and was joined by over 40 heads of state and government in Europe, Asia, Africa and Latin America. The summit was dedicated to the fight against the global pandemic-the coronavirus disease and aimed to boost coordination among member states in fight against the COVID-19 pandemic. In his opening remarks, the United Nations Secretary General Antonio Guterres stated that COVID-19 crisis had "exposed the fragility of our societies and economies to shocks, and it has laid bare deep inequalities that threaten the achievement of the Sustainable Development Goals" and that the developing countries needed massive support to address the gaps in their health systems and also to deal with the social and economic consequences of the pandemic. The UN Secretary-General remarked that with two-thirds of UN Member States, the Non-Aligned Movement has a critical role to play in forging global solidarity. There were three immediate priorities: to end the Covid-19 pandemic, to address its socio-economic impacts, and to use the recovery to build back better and leave no one behind. (United Nations 2020e).

Dr Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus, the Director General of the World Health Organization, while addressing the summit stated that multilateral & diplomatic cooperation were needed to ensure countries can respond effectively to COVID19, while strengthening preparedness for other emergencies. Dr Tedros said that the continued multilateral engagement of the Non-Aligned Movement was vital for tackling COVID-19 (Ghebreyesus 2020). The President of the 74th Session of the United Nations General Assembly, Prof. Tijjani Muhammad-Bande, who also participated in the virtual summit commended NAM Member States for their joint efforts in the fight against the pandemic. Bande stressed the importance of engaging all stakeholders including governments, multilateral institutions, the private sector and civil society to ensure that we respond to the specific needs of communities, including through ensuring equal access to treatments and vaccines without discrimination (United Nations 2020b).

The summit was addressed by the leaders of the NAM Member States. K P Sharma Oli, the Prime Minister of Nepal, stated that the Non-Aligned Movement must use its numerical and moral strength to unite the world at this critical moment of human history. He stressed the importance of South-South Cooperation by way of sharing experience, transfer of technology, medical logistics and equipment. He also emphasised that NAM must coordinate and advocate for launching of a robust recovery package from the international community to address the looming

economic recession (Government of Nepal 2020). The Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi emphasized the importance of a coordinated, inclusive and equitable response by the world to this crisis, outlining the steps India had taken domestically and internationally, while reaffirming India's readiness to offer assistance in solidarity with the Movement, to the extent possible. The Indian PM also emphasized the importance of a continued effort by the world against other viruses, in particular terrorism and fake news (Press Information Bureau 2020).

Following the Summit, NAM adopted a Declaration underlining the importance of international solidarity in the fight against COVID-19. This emphasis on international solidarity to fight the pandemic is in line with the United Nations General Assembly Resolution A/RES/74/270, entitled "Global solidarity to fight the coronavirus disease 2019 (COVID-19)[1]adopted on April 2, 2020 and A/RES/74/274, entitled "International cooperation to ensure global access to medicines, vaccines and medical equipment to face COVID-19"[2] adopted on April 20, 2020.

The NAM Declaration stated that mitigating the negative effects of COVID-19, required a global response based on unity, solidarity and renewed multilateral cooperation. The Declaration reiterated NAM's support to multilateralism with the United Nations at its core, and acknowledged that preserving and strengthening the values of multilateralism and international cooperation, which underpin the Charter of the United Nations and the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, was fundamental to promoting and supporting the three pillars of the United Nations – peace and security, development and human rights. Non-Aligned Movement also extended its support to the efforts of the World Health Organisation (WHO) and the critical role and guidance it was playing on the frontlines, including with the provision of guidance, training, equipment and concrete life-saving services.

The NAM Declaration also decided to establish the Non-Aligned Movement Task Force with the task to work out a database that would include the basic humanitarian and medical needs and requirements of NAM Member States, and which would be submitted by the Chairmanship to all donor countries, international humanitarian organizations, international financial institutions, transnational private entities implementing social responsibility projects and others for possible support and assistance (Non-Aligned Movement 2020c).

During the Summit, the President of Azerbaijan also announced the donation of 5 million USD to the WHO to support the most affected NAM Member States. Azerbaijan further launched an initiative to hold the UN General Assembly special session on COVID which was supported by an absolute majority of the international community. Azerbaijan also launched the initiative in United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC), with respect to equal and universal access to vaccines and fair distribution of vaccines (President of the Republic of Azerbaijan Ilham Aliyev 2020).

The Mid-term Ministerial Conference of the Non-Aligned Movement held on July 13 and 14, 2021, in an online mode further deliberated on the negative impacts of the COVID-19 pandemic on the developing world. The Political Declaration issued after the Mid-term Ministerial Conference recognised the importance of maintaining the continued functioning of the health system and strengthening of primary health care in all relevant aspects necessary for an effective public health response to the COVID-19 pandemic and other ongoing epidemics, including by ensuring the continuation of undisrupted vaccination programmes, with the view to achieving universal health coverage. The Declaration also noted with concern the disparity in distribution of safe, quality, efficacious, effective, accessible and affordable COVID-19 vaccines between high-income and low- and middle-income countries, which prevented the entire international community to achieve the complete elimination of the pandemic as soon as possible. The Declaration welcomed the efforts of countries which donated COVID-19 vaccines and encouraged further sharing of vaccines doses from all countries in a position to do so, without politicization to low- and middle-income countries and other countries in need, particularly through COVAX, including on the basis of the WHO allocation framework, for fair access and equitable allocation of COVID-19 vaccines health products (Non-Aligned Movement 2021).

It was on the initiative of the Non-Aligned Movement that a Special Session of the UN General Assembly in response to the COVID-19 pandemic was called on December 3-4, 2020. (United Nations 2020a). Ilham Aliyev, the President of Azerbaijan, and also the Chair of the 120-member Non-Aligned Movement, was one of the keynote speakers at this session in the latter capacity. The NAM Chair reiterated the principled position of NAM stressing the role of international solidarity and ensuring equitable access to vaccines as integral to effective pandemic response. Aliyev also highlighted a significant contribution of the Non-Aligned Movement in COVID-19 response mentioning that the WHO uses the NAM database as one of its reference points for identifying the existing needs of NAM Member states in addressing the pandemic. The NAM Chair also reiterated the Movement's support to the WHO and its leadership in "their critical role in providing guidance, training, equipment and concrete life-saving services, in order to ensure effective response of the international community to the ever-increasing challenges posed by the COVID-19 pandemic". The statement by the NAM Chair reaffirmed the importance of affordable, unhindered and equitable access by all countries to medicines, vaccines and medical equipment, which should constitute an integral part of a coordinated and effective global response to COVID-19. In conclusion, Aliyev highlighted the principled position of NAM that a concerted global response based on unity, multilateral cooperation, solidarity and respect for human rights was required to mitigate effects of COVID-19 and recover from the pandemic (Non-Aligned Movement 2020d).

The Non-Aligned Movement has also been actively participating in multilateral forums and voicing the concerns of the developing world caused by the COVID-19 pandemic. At the NAM summit, Azerbaijan, the NAM Chair, launched an initiative to hold the UN General Assembly special session

1 The Resolution called for intensified international cooperation to contain, mitigate and defeat the pandemic, including by exchanging information, scientific knowledge and best practices and by applying the relevant guidelines recommended by the World Health Organization and called upon United Nations system, under the leadership of the Secretary-General, to work with all relevant actors in order to mobilize a coordinated

global response to the pandemic and its adverse social, economic and financial impact on all societies (United Nations 2020c)

2 The Resolution encouraged the United Nations Member States to work in partnership with all relevant stakeholders to increase research and development funding for vaccines and medicines, leverage digital technologies, and strengthen scientific international cooperation necessary to combat COVID-19 and to bolster coordination, including with the private sector, towards rapid development, manufacturing and distribution of diagnostics, antiviral medicines, personal protective equipment and vaccines, adhering to the objectives of efficacy, safety, equity, accessibility, and affordability (United Nations 2020d).

on COVID which was supported by an absolute majority of the international community. Azerbaijan also launched the initiative in United Nations Human Rights Council, with respect to equal and universal access to vaccines and fair distribution of vaccines.

One of the major issues constantly highlighted by NAM is that of eliminating vaccine inequality and thereby striving towards vaccine equity. According to the UNDP, " Vaccine equity means that vaccines should be allocated across all countries based on needs and regardless of their economic status. Access to and allocation of vaccines should be based on principles grounded in the right of every human to enjoy the highest attainable standard of health without distinction of race, religion, political belief, economic, or any other social condition" (UNDP 2022). High-income countries started vaccination on average two months earlier than low-income countries and vaccination coverage in low-income countries is still strikingly low. Data clearly shows the prevalence of vaccine inequality with reference to the less developed countries. According to the 2022 United Nations Finance for Sustainable Development Report, Vaccine inequity remains high—the number of vaccine doses per 100 people in least developed countries (LDCs) stood at just 23.9, against 147.4 in developed countries (United Nations 2022: XIII). The UN recognises that boosting access to vaccines in developing countries is key to stopping the undermining the global and regional supply chains as the production systems are interconnected. In October 2021, International Chamber of Commerce's Secretary-General, John Denton, warned that the global economy stood to lose as much as $9.2 trillion, with developed countries shouldering half the cost, if governments failed to ensure developing countries' access to COVID-19 vaccines (UNCTAD 2021).

During the 46th session of the United Nations Human Rights Council, Ecuador and Azerbaijan on behalf of the Non-Aligned Movement tabled a Resolution "Ensuring equitable, affordable, timely and universal access for all countries to vaccines in response to the coronavirus disease (COVID-19) pandemic", which was adopted without a vote on 23 March 2021. The contents of this Resolution highlight the approach of the NAM towards countering COVID pandemic.

The Resolution recognised that the availability of vaccines, medicines, health technologies and health therapies is an essential dimension of the right of everyone to the enjoyment of the highest attainable standard of physical and mental health. It further recognised that universal health coverage implies that all people have access without discrimination to nationally determined sets of needed promotive, preventive, curative, palliative and rehabilitative essential healthcare services and essential, safe, affordable, effective and quality medicines and vaccines, while ensuring that the use of these services does not expose users to financial hardship, with special emphasis on the poor, vulnerable and marginalized segments of the population.

The Resolution noted with concern the disparity between developing countries and developed countries in terms of the distribution of COVID-19 vaccines, which prevents the entire international community from achieving the complete elimination of COVID-19 as soon as possible, and also further hampers progress in the realization of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. The Resolution, presented by NAM, recognised the importance of international cooperation and effective multilateralism in ensuring that all States, in particular developing States, including the least developed States, have affordable, timely, equitable and universal access to COVID-19 vaccines in order to minimize negative effects in all affected States and to avoid the resurgence of the pandemic. The Resolution also expressed deep concerns that the COVID-19 pandemic perpetuated and exacerbated existing inequalities and that those most at risk are persons in vulnerable and marginalized situations, including older persons, migrants, refugees, internally displaced persons, persons with disabilities, persons belonging to minorities, indigenous peoples, persons deprived of their liberty, homeless persons and persons living in poverty. NAM has thus stressed the need to ensure non-discrimination and equality while stressing the importance of age-responsive, gender responsive and disability-sensitive measures in this regard.

The Resolution by NAM also stressed the important role of the Access to COVID-19 Tools (ACT) Accelerator initiative[3] and called for strengthening the COVID-19 Vaccine Global Access (COVAX) Facility.[4]. Non-Aligned Movement has also called upon States, other partners and donors to urgently support funding and close the funding gap for the Access to COVID-19 Tools Accelerator and its mechanisms, such as the COVID-19 Vaccine Global Access (COVAX) Facility, to support the equitable distribution of diagnostics, therapeutics and vaccines and to further explore innovative financing mechanisms aimed at ensuring affordable, timely, equitable and universal access to, and the fair distribution of, COVID-19 vaccines for all and the continuity and strengthening of essential health services. The Movement has also called on States and other relevant stakeholders to remove unjustified obstacles restricting the export of COVID-19 vaccines, resulting in an unequal distribution in access to them between developed and developing countries, and to promote equitable global distribution and universal access to vaccines, in order to further the principles of international cooperation and solidarity, to end the current pandemic and to promote the realization of the right of everyone to the enjoyment of the highest attainable standard of physical and mental health.

The Resolution presented by NAM also reaffirmed the right of States to use the provisions of the World Trade Organization Agreement on Trade-Related Aspects of Intellectual Property Rights (TRIPS Agreement) and the flexibilities therein, as reaffirmed in the Doha Declaration on the TRIPS Agreement and Public Health, in which it is recognized that the agreement should be interpreted and implemented in a manner supportive of the right of States to protect public health, in particular to promote access to medicines for all, to facilitate access for all to COVID-19 vaccines and to bolster coordination, including with the private sector, towards the rapid development, manufacturing and distribution of vaccines, while adhering to the objectives of transparency, efficacy, safety, equity, accessibility and affordability (United Nations 2021b)

The Non-Aligned Movement also called for declaring COVID-19 related vaccines as global public good and reiterated the need for accelerated efforts for unhindered, equal, equitable and affordable access and provision of COVID-19 related diagnostics, therapeutics and vaccines to everyone and everywhere (Non-Aligned Movement 2020a).

In December 2021, the United Nations General Assembly adopted a resolution on equitable access to COVID-19 vaccines, initiated by Azerbaijan and co-sponsored by 126 countries

3 The Access to COVID-19 Tools (ACT) Accelerator, launched in April 2020 is a global collaboration to accelerate development, production, and equitable access to COVID-19 tests, treatments, and vaccines

4 COVAX is the vaccines pillar of the Access to COVID-19 Tools (ACT) Accelerator. Its aim is to accelerate the development and manufacture of COVID-19 vaccines, and to guarantee fair and equitable access for every country in the world.

(Lmahamad 2021). Akin to the Resolution presented by the Non-Aligned Movement in the UNHRC, the NAM Resolution " Ensuring equitable, affordable, timely and universal access for all countries to vaccines in response to the coronavirus disease (COVID-19) pandemic" adopted by the UNGA on December 16, 2021, takes into account the concerns of developing world in combating the COVID-19 pandemic, stressing the significance of international solidarity and the need to eliminate vaccine inequality. The Resolution reiterated the fundamental role of the United Nations system in coordinating the global response to control and contain the spread of COVID-19 and in providing support to States, and in this regard acknowledged the leading role played by the World Health Organization, in line with its constitutional mandate. The Resolution noted with concern the uneven access to quality, safe, efficacious and affordable COVID-19 vaccine and the difficulties that a large number of countries face in gaining access to and supplying them to their populations, stressing the important role of the Access to COVID-19 Tools (ACT) Accelerator initiative and of other relevant initiatives that are aimed at accelerating the development and production of and equitable access to COVID-19 diagnostics, therapeutics and vaccines for all countries and at strengthening health systems, and recognizing in particular the vaccines pillar of the COVID-19 Vaccine Global Access (COVAX) Facility, which is aimed at ensuring an equitable global distribution of vaccines to all States. It also called on States to facilitate the trade in, acquisition of, access to and distribution of COVID-19 vaccines as a crucial element of their responses to the pandemic, to ensure the right of everyone to the enjoyment of the highest attainable standard of physical and mental health and to support the administration of vaccines to address the pandemic, in line with the Sustainable Development Goals.

The Resolution presented by NAM also welcomed the decision of the International Monetary Fund to allocate special drawing rights[5] to boost global liquidity and enhance the resilience of the international monetary system and called on countries to consider voluntarily channelling unutilized special drawing rights, in accordance with national laws and regulations, to the countries which are most in need, including the middle-income countries, to better support sustainable development and a more inclusive recovery, and stresses the importance of ensuring equal access to such resources, to guarantee timely and universal access to COVID-19 vaccines.

The Non-Aligned Movement has also urged Member States to promote an enhanced response to future pandemics, based on the lessons learned from COVID-19, by strengthening the capacities required under the International Health Regulations (2005)[6] and by considering the benefits of developing a WHO convention or other international instruments on pandemic preparedness and response (United Nations 2021).

5 In August 2021, the IMF approved a general allocation of Special Drawing Rights (SDRs) equivalent to US$650 billion (about SDR 456 billion) on August 2, 2021, to boost global liquidity. About US$275 billion (about SDR 193 billion) of the new allocation will go to emerging markets and developing countries, including low-income countries (International Monetary Fund 2021).

6 196 countries across the globe have agreed to implement the International Health Regulations (2005) (IHR). This binding instrument of international law entered into force on 15 June 2007.

The stated purpose and scope of the IHR are "to prevent, protect against, control and provide a public health response to the international spread of disease in ways that are commensurate with and restricted to public health risks, and which avoid unnecessary interference with international traffic and trade." (World Health Organisation 2008).

CONCLUSION

The response of the NAM to the COVID crisis shows that the Movement continues to be relevant in the contemporary world and removes all apprehensions about it. NAM has shown that it remains the largest collective forum from which the developing world articulates its best interest. The above discussion clearly manifested that it was the Non-Aligned Movement that raised the problems faced by developing countries both during and after the COVID crisis. Not only has the NAM remained firm in its commitment to multilateralism, the Movement has also demonstrated the collective power of the global South, as is evident by the Resolutions on COVID-19 and vaccine equity introduced in multilateral bodies such as the UNGA and the UNHRC. NAM's response and its active involvement in multilateral forums in determining a global concerted response to the crisis shows that the Movement has adopted itself in line with the contemporary international situation and is a manifestation of the collective power of the developing world.

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